

Technical Assessment for Customer Service Position.

It is 4:45 PM on a Friday before a holiday weekend. You are currently managing three high-priority issues simultaneously:

1. **The Angry Outage:** A long-term client is calling because their service has been down for 2 hours, costing them revenue. They are shouting and demanding an immediate refund and a call with the CEO.
2. **The Delivery Failure:** A first-time customer is on live chat. Their package was marked as "Delivered" but they don't have it. It contains a time-sensitive gift for a wedding tomorrow.
3. **The Internal Error:** You just noticed a system-wide bug that will likely affect 50% of our user base within the next hour if not addressed by the technical team.

Your Task: Draft a written response for each of the two customers above (the Phone Caller and the Chat User) and an internal message to the Technical Team. Your submission will be evaluated on:

- **Prioritization:** In what order do you handle these, and why?
- **De-escalation:** How do you move the "Angry Outage" caller from shouting to collaborating?
- **Problem Solving:** What creative, immediate solutions do you offer the "Delivery Failure" customer given the holiday weekend?
- **Tone & Accuracy:** Your ability to remain calm, professional, and precise under extreme pressure.

MY ANSWER FOR THE TASKS ABOVE:

1. The Internal Error (First)

Half of our users are down. If we don't fix the "engine" now, thousands of people will start calling and we won't be able to help anyone. Fix this first to stop the flood.

2. The Delivery Failure (Second)

A wedding is happening tomorrow and the shipping hubs are closing for the holiday. This is a "now or never" situation. We need to move fast to get this package out the door.

3. The Angry Outage (Third)

These guys are loud and pay a lot, but their problem takes time to fix.

1. Internal Message (To: Technical Team)

Subject: URGENT: Potential 50% Outage - Bug Identified

Team, I've identified a system-wide bug likely to impact 50% of our users within the next hour. Given the holiday weekend, we need an immediate hotfix or rollback to prevent a total support collapse. I am currently triaging high-priority escalations. Please confirm receipt and provide an ETA for a fix ASAP.

2. Live Chat Response (The Delivery Failure)

"I can hear how much this matters - having a wedding gift go missing is incredibly stressful. Since it's marked 'Delivered' but not there, I won't waste your time with a standard 3-day investigation.

I am personally calling a local courier in your area right now to see if we have a partner boutique with the same item in stock that can hand-deliver it to you this evening. If not, I am authorizing an emergency replacement. I'll stay on this chat with you until we have a tracking number or a delivery confirmation."

3. Phone Script (The Angry Outage)

"I understand, [Name], and I completely recognize why this is so frustrating. If I saw my revenue dropping on a Friday afternoon, I would feel the exact same way.

Here is exactly what I am doing to resolve this: I have escalated your case to our lead developers. Our leadership team is working directly with them right now to finalize a fix. I have also added a note to your account to ensure you receive a service credit once we are back online.

I want to make sure you stay informed, so I will call you every 20 minutes with a status update—even if it is just to let you know we are still making progress. Does that work for you?"

Bonus Challenge: The "Policy vs. Person" Decision

I chose to authorize the emergency replacement despite the international overnight restriction because the total business risk extended beyond a single shipment cost. The customer's wedding gift was time-sensitive, emotionally significant, and already impacted by a delivery failure outside their control. In that context, strict policy enforcement would likely have caused disproportionate reputational damage, including public negative reviews and loss of long-term customer value. I documented the exception, escalated it immediately, and selected the

lowest-cost expedited option available to minimize financial exposure while protecting trust in the brand.

Proposed SOP Change:

Create a “Customer Recovery Exception Tier” that allows supervisors or senior agents to approve one-time expedited replacements for high-emotion, high-visibility cases (weddings, funerals, milestone events) using a capped budget and clear approval criteria.

Explain Your Process

Here is my brief explanation on how and why:

First, I approached the situation by focusing on impact, urgency, and customer trust. My first priority was the internal system bug because it could affect 50% of users within an hour. Preventing a large-scale outage protects both customers and the company from a much bigger crisis. I immediately alerted the technical team so they could begin a rollback or hotfix while I continued handling customer escalations.

Second, I handled the delivery failure because the issue was time-sensitive and tied to a wedding happening the next day. Since holiday delays reduce recovery options, I focused on fast action and emotional reassurance instead of giving a standard scripted response. I offered immediate alternatives and stayed engaged until a solution was confirmed.

Third, I addressed the outage client by de-escalating first, then rebuilding trust through transparency and consistent updates. Instead of arguing or overpromising, I acknowledged the financial impact, explained the escalation steps, and created a predictable communication plan to move the conversation from anger to cooperation.